

WORKING WITH WINDOWS

There's no understating the fact that most likely you are going to be working with one Windows operating system or the other. So, getting to know the OS is quite important

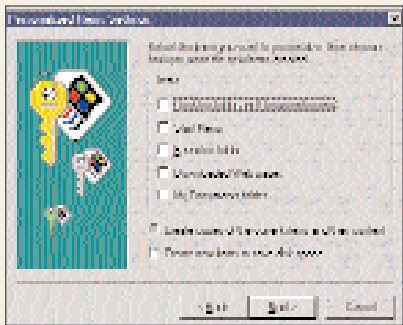
Windows 9x/Me

The most popular operating system is not that security conscious, but you can certainly tweak it to gain more control

Creating security policies

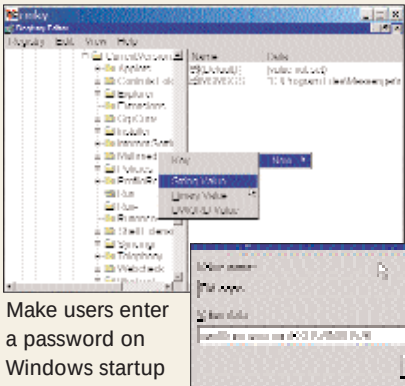
You can get a higher level of security with your Windows machine if you create user profiles on your PC. Go to Control Panel, double-click the Users option and follow the wizard to create a new user for the computer.

If you are using Windows 95, you have to select the Passwords option to go to the User Profiles tab. Enable users can customise the preferences and restart the computer. In the login window, type in your name and password, and Windows will prompt you for creating a new profile.



You can specify rights for individual users

Now, with user profiles created, you can use the System Policy Editor to restrict access to new users (or those who just hit the Cancel button at the login menu). Before using Policy Editor, back up your registry and other password files. Restart the computer, and at the login prompt, press Cancel. This represents a setting for an unauthorised user. Start the Policy Editor by typing poedit in the Run menu. Go to File > Open Registry and double-click on Local Users. Check or uncheck the various options to restrict access by an



unauthorised user. Click OK when you are finished. The settings you choose are the ones a person will find when he logs in with a new name or hits Cancel at the login prompt. This can be a very stripped down version of Windows with no access to many of the settings or folders.

Forcing users to enter password during login

Unlike Windows NT/2000, the login window in Windows 9x/Me can be easily bypassed by pressing the [Esc] key or by clicking Cancel. So, it's possible that a third person who turns on your PC can gain access to your personal information. To prevent this from happening, first make sure that the user profiles are created and enabled for each user, and that the 'Include Start Menu and Program Groups in User Settings' option in the Control Panel is enabled for each user.

Reboot the PC in Safe Mode by hitting the [F8] key during Startup and choosing Safe Mode from the Boot Options. This is very important because if something goes wrong, you can always reboot your computer in the safe mode and rectify the problem.

Type regedit.exe in Start > Run. Find the following key in the Registry: HKEY_USERS\Default\Software\Micros

oft/Windows/CurrentVersion/Run. In the right-hand pane, right-click and choose New String Values, and rename it as FixLogon. Finally, open the FixLogon entry you've just created (by double-clicking on the right-pane of the Registry Editor window) and specify the following command as its Value data: rundll.exe user.exe, EXITWINDOWS. Reboot your PC to save the changes. If you want to restore the old setting, delete this key.

Installing Critical Updates

A feature that often goes unnoticed in Windows (and other applications too) is the update utility. Microsoft uses the term 'Critical' updates for patches and bug fixes related to your operating system, though sometimes these may be for other applications too. While you can go and individually download the updates from Microsoft's Web site, you can do the entire thing in a faster manner by just clicking on the Start menu and selecting Windows update. This ensures that you get the entire database of updates in some central location. It's not necessary that you install each and every update, especially if you have not been facing any problems. And the latest updates for Outlook Express have made it extremely restrictive. But, do select the updates that fix any exploits to your browser or operating system and install them.

Disabling sharing

If your machine is part of a network, you need to configure it for file and print sharing so as to enable other people on the network to access your shared folders and printers, and to allow you in turn to access their resources. But most intrusions are done using this exploit to gain access to your machine.

On the other hand, if you have a stand-alone machine, then there's no reason

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